

# BIGGEST HACKS AND SCAMS

OF 2020s, HALF A DECADE OF DIGITAL DECEPTION

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**T**he 2020s have marked a pivotal and transformative era in cybersecurity, characterised by audacious cyberattacks and sophisticated scams that have exploited vulnerabilities in technology, human trust, and regulatory gaps. From state-sponsored espionage to opportunistic frauds, cybercriminals have dramatically redefined the threat landscape, targeting individuals, corporations, and critical infrastructure alike. These incidents highlight the rapidly evolving tactics of cybercriminals, their wide-reaching societal impact, and the urgent need for robust, adaptive defenses.

## 1. Twitter crypto scam hack

Before being bought over by Elon Musk and getting renamed to X, in July 2020, Twitter suffered one of the most high-profile breaches of the decade, compromising 69 accounts belonging to prominent figures like Elon Musk, Barack Obama, Bill Gates, and companies like Apple and Uber. The attackers, led by a 17-year-old from Florida named Graham

Ivan Clark, used social engineering to trick Twitter employees into providing access to internal administrative tools.

By exploiting weak credential security, they posted fraudulent tweets promoting a Bitcoin scam, promising to double any cryptocurrency sent to

its security practices. Clark and his accomplices were arrested, with Clark later pleading guilty and receiving a three-year prison sentence. The incident, described as a wake-up call for social media platforms, raised alarms about election security, given Twitter's role in



public discourse. It prompted the company to implement stricter access controls, multi-factor authentication (MFA), and employee training to prevent similar attacks.

The Twitter hack stressed the persistent threat of social engineering, where human error remains a critical vulnerability. It also highlighted the need for platforms to

a specified wallet. Within hours, the hackers amassed over \$100,000 in Bitcoin. The breach exposed Twitter's inadequate internal controls, as the attackers accessed a dashboard that allowed them to control high-value accounts without robust authentication.

The fallout was swift: Twitter locked down affected accounts, removed the tweets, and faced intense scrutiny over

secure their internal systems as rigorously as their public-facing ones, setting a precedent for industry-wide reforms.

## 2. SolarWinds supply-chain attack

The SolarWinds hack, uncovered in December 2020, was a landmark supply chain attack attributed to Russian state-sponsored actors, likely the Cozy Bear